



THE SITE FOR THE MARADONA-BACKED INDIAN FOOTBALL SCHOOL; (RIGHT) THE MASTER PLAN FOR BAYERN MUNICH'S ACADEMY IN BURDWAN

ACCORDING TO GERMAN LEGEND GERD MULLER, TRAINEES WILL PRODUCE RESULTS ONLY AFTER FOUR TO FIVE YEARS.

six months. German legend Muller, now the assistant coach of the junior Bayern Munich team, told INDIA TODAY that it would take, "four to five years" to see how trainees shape up. "We have to induct young players and improve basic skills. Not much can be done with elder players. An academy can show that way."

All these plans may be frustratingly long-term for a country yearning for results but TFA coach Ranjan Chowdhury believes the next decade will prove to be crucial—and very beneficial—for Indian football. "Foreign clubs are now getting into India and China. Football will become a big industry, just like it happened in Africa," he says.

Subrata Dutta, All-India Football Federation (AIFF) vice-president and a driving force behind the Indian Football Association (IFA) academy in Haldia, says Maradona's visits may not directly contribute to Indian football, yet "what it definitely does is bring football to the first page and make big sponsors aware and the government ready to chip in. It is up to the administrators like us, and people who are trying to develop the game, to cash in. We not only need academies for players, but also proper education for coaches and referees."

The IFA academy, set up in 2004, was the first academy in India to be opened by a state football association,



SUVASHIS MULLICK

THE HANDS OF GLOBAL GODS

The involvement of international players may boost training in India

1 The "Maradona" School

Formally called the Indian Football School, this academy backed by soccer legend Maradona will only be functional after 2012. Forty students are likely to be trained here.

2 Bayern Munich Academy

No date has been fixed for the start of Bayern Munich's academy. The process for scouting players and coaches will start in six months.

but has produced only one batch in the last four years. Having started with 24 trainees, under coach Sujit Chakraborty, the academy roped in foreign expertise, holding special coaching sessions with Jurgen Mosthaff (Germany) and Philippe de Ridder (Belgium). The first batch is now ready for the football market and the next batch will be inducted from February.

Dutta explains the pace of progress saying that the infrastructure available is not enough to accommodate more boys. "We just have one ground, so more than one group cannot be trained," he says. The lack of facilities cannot quite make up for the worthiness of the intent.

The other prominent residential academy in the eastern zone is Bokaro's SAIL Academy, where trainees until recently worked under the legendary Peter Thangaraj. Pradip Chowdhury, manager of the Indian football team, also at SAIL academy along with former goalkeeper Tarun

